“In reality, we are *Pan narrans*, the storytelling chimpanzee.”

Terry Pratchett

British fantasy author

Making connections

Leakey’s fieldwork focused on looking for the “missing link”—fossils of transitional forms between that common ancestor and humans. Chimpanzees had not been studied seriously in the wild and such a study, he reasoned, could throw light on the evolution of early humans. Goodall, a keen observer and free of academic ties, was the ideal choice for the work. As Leakey had hoped, she provided a fresh perspective on the theory and was brave enough to say that chimps and humans were more alike than had been imagined. Until this point, the scientific and popular consensus was that the ability to devise and make tools marked humans out as superior to the rest of the animal kingdom. Goodall’s findings forced scientists to think again.

Goodall’s camp was in Gombe Stream National Park, Tanzania, where she studied a chimp community on the eastern shore of Lake Tanganyika. In choosing to live among chimps to witness their true unfettered behavior, Goodall was one of the first people to work in the field of ethology, whereby biologists monitor animals in their natural environments and try to understand their natural behaviors. In her first few months at the camp, the chimps fled from her, but they then began to forget she was there.

Goodall observed the chimps for many hours, keeping her distance and quietly making field notes. One day in November 1961, she noticed a chimpanzee she called David Greybeard sitting over a termite mound. He was poking blades of grass into the mound, pulling them out, and then putting them into his mouth. She watched for some time before the chimp moved off. At the spot where the chimp had been sitting, Goodall saw